

The Blender's Cheat Sheet

Famous wine blends — grapes, typical percentages, ranges, and what each variety contributes | kazmicellars.com

Wine blending is one of winemaking's greatest arts. Each grape variety brings something different — colour, aroma, tannin, acidity, body, or longevity. Understanding what goes into a blend (and why) unlocks the logic behind why each wine tastes the way it does. Percentages shown are typical for the style — individual estates and vintages vary significantly. An asterisk (*) denotes an optional variety.

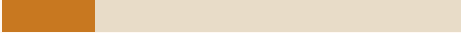
FRANCE

Bordeaux Left Bank

RED

France · Médoc · Pauillac · Margaux · Saint-Julien · Saint-Estèphe · Graves

Structure and longevity — Cabernet Sauvignon is the anchor, Merlot adds softness, Petit Verdot provides colour and spice.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Cabernet Sauvignon		70%	50–85% The backbone and the star
Merlot		20%	10–40% Rounds the tannins
Cabernet Franc		8%	3–20% Adds herbal lift
Petit Verdot		2%	0–5% Colour and spice — used sparingly
Malbec *		1%	0–3% Rarely used today

Rules: No single variety need dominate — the blend is the winemaker's art. But Cab Sauv almost always leads on the Left Bank.

Note: The percentage shifts significantly by property and vintage. In cool years, more Merlot is used to add softness. Graves uses more Cab Franc.

Examples: Château Latour, Château Mouton Rothschild, Château Léoville-Las-Cases, Château Palmer

Bordeaux Right Bank

RED

France · Pomerol · Saint-Émilion

Merlot-dominant richness — plush, earlier-drinking, and deeply influenced by the clay and limestone soils of the Right Bank.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Merlot		80%	60–95% The dominant force — sometimes 100%
Cabernet Franc		15%	5–40% Adds structure and aromatic lift
Cabernet Sauvignon *		5%	0–15% Minor role on the Right Bank

Rules: Merlot must lead. Pomerol allows only Merlot, Cab Franc, Cab Sauv, and Malbec. Saint-Émilion additionally allows Carménère and Petit Verdot.

Note: Château Pétrus is essentially 100% Merlot — one of the world's most famous wines from a single variety 'blend'. Cheval Blanc is famously Cab Franc-dominant (~57%) — the great exception.

Examples: *Château Pétrus, Château Le Pin, Château Cheval Blanc, Château Figeac, Château Ausone*

White Bordeaux (Dry)

WHITE

France · Pessac-Léognan · Entre-Deux-Mers · Bordeaux Blanc

Sauvignon Blanc for freshness and aromatics, Sémillon for texture, weight, and ageing potential.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Sauvignon Blanc		65%	50–85% Aromatics, citrus, freshness
Sémillon		30%	15–50% Texture, waxy depth, ageing
Muscadelle *		5%	0–8% Adds floral note — rarely over 5%

Rules: Most dry white Bordeaux is majority Sauvignon Blanc. Premium Graves (Domaine de Chevalier, Haut-Brion Blanc) uses more Sémillon for complexity.

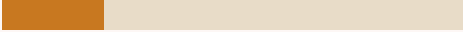
Examples: *Château Haut-Brion Blanc, Domaine de Chevalier Blanc, Château Smith Haut Lafitte Blanc*

Sauternes (Sweet White Bordeaux)

SWEET

France · Sauternes · Barsac

The percentages reverse — *Sémillon* dominates because its thin skin makes it susceptible to noble rot (*botrytis*), the key to Sauternes' character.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Sémillon		75%	60–95% Primary <i>botrytis</i> vehicle — honey, wax, apricot
Sauvignon Blanc		22%	5–35% Freshness and acidity — essential balance
Muscadelle *		3%	0–8% Floral complexity

- Rules:** Must be made from *botrytis*-affected grapes. Grapes are harvested in multiple passes (tries) as noble rot develops unevenly. The resulting wines must have minimum 13% alcohol equivalent.
- Note:** Château d'Yquem uses approximately 80% *Sémillon* / 20% *Sauvignon Blanc*. The ratio varies by vintage depending on which variety was better affected by *botrytis* that year.
- Examples:** *Château d'Yquem, Château Rieussec, Château Suduiraut, Château Guiraud*

Châteauneuf-du-Pape (Red)

RED

France · Châteauneuf-du-Pape AOC — Southern Rhône

Up to 18 grape varieties permitted — the most permissive blend in France. Grenache dominates; everything else adds complexity, colour, and structure.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Grenache Noir		70%	40–90% The heart — spice, red fruit, warmth
Syrah		12%	5–25% Colour, pepper, structure
Mourvèdre		8%	5–20% Depth, dark fruit, earthiness
Cinsault *		5%	0–15% Freshness, perfume
Counoise *		2%	0–8% Acidity and finesse
Roussanne (white) *		2%	0–5% White grape co-fermented in red — legal and traditional
Others (up to 13 varieties total) *		1%	0–5% Vaccarèse, Picardan, Terret Noir, Muscardin, Clairette, Bourboulenc

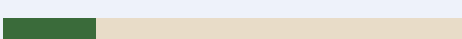
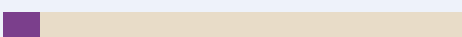
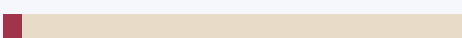
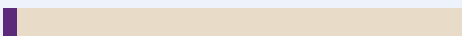
- Rules:** Grenache, Syrah, and Mourvèdre are the primary varieties but none are mandatory. Interestingly, white grape varieties (Roussanne, Clairette, Bourboulenc) may legally be included in the red blend.
- Note:** Château Rayas is the great exception — 100% Grenache from very old vines. Château Beaucastel famously uses all 18 permitted varieties and emphasises Mourvèdre far above the regional norm.
- Examples:** *Château Rayas, Château Beaucastel, Château Pégau, Château Fortia, Clos des Papes*

Châteauneuf-du-Pape (White)

WHITE

France · Châteauneuf-du-Pape AOC — Southern Rhône

Rare, complex, and expensive — one of France's most underrated white wines. Rich, aromatic, and built for the table.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Grenache Blanc		30%	15–50% Weight and roundness
Roussanne		25%	10–50% Aromatics, complexity, ageing
Clairette		20%	10–40% Freshness, floral notes
Bourboulenc *		10%	0–20% Acidity and elegance
Picpoul *		8%	0–15% Freshness
Picardan / Piquepoult *		4%	0–10% Rare — adds floral lift
Viognier *		3%	0–10% Not traditional but permitted

Rules: White CdP is only a tiny fraction of total production. Château Beaucastel's Roussanne Vieilles Vignes is 100% Roussanne — the great exception.

Examples: Château Beaucastel Blanc, Château Rayas Blanc, Château La Nerthe Blanc

Côte-Rôtie

RED

France · Côte-Rôtie AOC — Northern Rhône

Syrah with up to 20% Viognier — the only AOC that legally allows a white grape to be co-fermented with a red. The result is a wine of extraordinary perfume.

GRAPE	TYPICAL	RANGE
Syrah	95%	80–100% The wine — iron, violet, pepper, smoked meat
Viognier *	5%	0–20% White grape co-fermented with Syrah — adds violet and apricot aroma

Rules: Viognier may be co-fermented with Syrah up to 20%. This is not a separate addition — the white grapes are harvested and fermented with the red grapes together. Most producers use 5% or less.

Note: The two great hillsides — Côte Brune (dark iron-rich schist, more structured) and Côte Blonde (lighter sandy soils, more perfumed) — are often blended. The Viognier proportion varies by producer philosophy.

Examples: E. Guigal La Mouline (Côte Blonde), Guigal La Landonne (Côte Brune), Chapoutier, Jean-Michel Gerin

Bandol (Red)

RED

France · Bandol AOC — Provence

Mourvèdre rules in Bandol — the only AOC where it is the mandatory dominant variety. Wild, gamey, and built for long ageing.

GRAPE	TYPICAL	RANGE
Mourvèdre	70%	50–95% Mandatory minimum 50% — often much higher
Grenache	18%	5–40% Softens and adds red fruit
Cinsault	10%	5–25% Freshness and perfume
Syrah *	2%	0–10% Minor supporting role

Rules: Mourvèdre must make up at least 50% of the blend. Bandol red must be aged a minimum of 18 months in oak — 3 years for some estates.

Note: Bandol red is one of France's most age-worthy wines — great examples need 10–20 years. The savory, animal character of Mourvèdre is the defining flavour.

Examples: Domaine Tempier, Château de Pibarnon, Domaine du Gros Noré, Château Pradeaux

Champagne

SPARKLING

France · Champagne AOC

Three grapes, infinite combinations — the winemaker's art is in the blend. Chardonnay for finesse, Pinot Noir for structure and depth, Pinot Meunier for roundness and early approachability.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Chardonnay		35%	0–100% Blanc de Blancs = 100%. Adds elegance, citrus, mineral.
Pinot Noir		40%	0–100% Blanc de Noirs style. Adds body, red fruit, structure.
Pinot Meunier		25%	0–100% Rounds the wine. Approachable early. Often dominant in NV blends.

Rules: Blanc de Blancs = 100% Chardonnay. Blanc de Noirs = Pinot Noir and/or Pinot Meunier only (white wine from red grapes). Rosé Champagne is made either by blending red wine in, or by brief skin contact.

Note: Each house has a signature style defined by their NV blend ratios. Krug uses a very high Pinot Noir proportion. Salon is 100% Chardonnay. Bollinger emphasises Pinot Noir. The NV blend typically includes wines from multiple vintages to ensure consistency.

Examples: Krug Grande Cuvée, Salon Blanc de Blancs, Bollinger Special Cuvée, Pol Roger, Dom Pérignon

Provence Rosé

ROSE

France · Côtes de Provence · Bandol Rosé · Coteaux d'Aix-en-Provence

The world's benchmark dry rosé — Grenache and Cinsault dominate, with Mourvèdre, Syrah, and Carignan adding complexity. The blend defines the style of Provence.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Grenache		45%	20–70% Red fruit, roundness, warmth
Cinsault		25%	10–40% Freshness, perfume, elegant colour
Mourvèdre		15%	5–30% Structure and savory depth
Syrah *		10%	0–20% Colour, spice
Carignan *		5%	0–15% Acidity and structure
Tibouren *		2%	0–10% Local variety — adds perfume

Rules: Minimum 20% of Grenache, Cinsault, or Mourvèdre. Carignan may not exceed 40% in Côtes de Provence.

Note: The colour of Provence rosé (very pale salmon/onion skin) is deliberately achieved by minimal skin contact. Darker rosés exist but the market demand has pushed producers toward paleness.

Examples: *Domaine Ott, Château d'Esclans (Whispering Angel), Miraval, Château Sainte Roseline*

ITALY

Super Tuscan — Sassicaia Style

RED

Italy · Bolgheri Sassicaia DOC · IGT Toscana

The original Super Tuscan — Cabernet Sauvignon and Cabernet Franc planted in Tuscany, inspired by Bordeaux, breaking Italian wine law to create something magnificent.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Cabernet Sauvignon		85%	75–90% The driver — Tuscan sun on a Bordeaux grape
Cabernet Franc		15%	10–25% Lifts the herbal complexity

Rules: Sassicaia was originally classified as a lowly 'Vino da Tavola' (table wine) because it didn't follow Italian DOC rules. In 1994 it became the only single-estate DOC in Italy — Bolgheri Sassicaia DOC.

Note: The Super Tuscan movement began in the 1970s when visionary producers broke Italian DOC rules by blending French varieties. They filed the wines as IGT (Indicazione Geografica Tipica) — technically a lower classification — yet sold them as some of Italy's most expensive wines.

Examples: Sassicaia (Tenuta San Guido), Ornellaia, Grattamacco

Super Tuscan — Tignanello Style

RED

Italy · IGT Toscana

Sangiovese meets international varieties — a hybrid blend that bridges Italian tradition and Bordeaux ambition. The wine that changed Italian winemaking forever.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Sangiovese		78%	70–85% The Tuscan soul — sour cherry, herbs, leather
Cabernet Sauvignon		15%	10–20% Adds structure, colour, and dark fruit depth
Cabernet Franc		7%	5–15% Herbal lift and aromatic complexity

Rules: No strict rules — IGT Toscana is a broad category allowing almost any variety. The Tignanello blend (by Antinori) is proprietary.

Note: Antinori created Tignanello in 1971. It was the first Sangiovese-based wine to be aged in small French oak barriques — another rule-breaking innovation that changed Italian wine culture. Each producer's 'Tignanello style' varies.

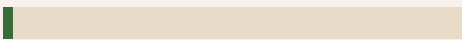
Examples: Tignanello (Antinori), Summus (Castello Banfi), Flaccianello della Pieve (Fontodi)

Chianti Classico

RED

Italy · Chianti Classico DOCG — Tuscany

Sangiovese at its most food-friendly — the blend adds softness and colour while Sangiovese's acidity and sour cherry character remain front and centre.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Sangiovese		90%	80–100% Must be minimum 80% — the law
Canaiolo *		5%	0–15% Traditional Tuscan variety — softens tannins
Colorino *		2%	0–8% Adds deep colour
Cabernet Sauvignon / Merlot *		3%	0–20% International varieties — capped at 20% for Classico, 0% for Gran Selezione

Rules: Chianti Classico: minimum 80% Sangiovese. Gran Selezione (the top tier): 100% Sangiovese from a single vineyard. No international varieties permitted in Gran Selezione.

Note: The classic black rooster (Gallo Nero) on the neck label indicates Chianti Classico — not regular Chianti. Gran Selezione was introduced in 2014 as a premium single-vineyard, 100% Sangiovese tier.

Examples: *Fonterutoli, Badia a Coltibuono, Castello di Ama, Isole e Olena, Castello di Volpaia*

Amarone della Valpolicella

RED

Italy · Amarone della Valpolicella DOCG — Veneto

Made from dried grapes — the appassimento process concentrates everything. Corvina is the backbone; the blend adds colour, aroma, and complexity to one of Italy's most powerful wines.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Corvina Veronese		65%	45–95% The heart — sour cherry, bitter almond, spice
Corvinone		20%	0–50% Can substitute up to 50% of Corvina — adds depth
Rondinella		12%	5–30% Colour and cherry notes
Oseleta *		2%	0–5% Rare native variety — adds spice and tannin
Molinara *		1%	0–5% Being phased out — was historically more common

Rules: Grapes must be dried (appassimento) for a minimum of 90 days before pressing. This concentrates sugars, acids, and aromas. Fermentation is long and difficult. Minimum 14% ABV.

Note: Ripasso ('Valpolicella Ripasso') is made by referencing lighter Valpolicella wine over the leftover Amarone skins — a 'second wine' method that adds richness without making a full Amarone.

Examples: Quintarelli, Dal Forno Romano, Bertani, Allegrini, Masi

SPAIN

Rioja (Red)

RED

Spain · DOCa Rioja

Tempranillo is the star — Garnacha adds warmth and fruit, Graciano adds acidity and colour, Mazuelo adds structure. American or French oak ageing defines the house style.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Tempranillo		80%	60–100% The anchor — dried cherry, leather, tobacco
Garnacha		12%	0–30% Warmth, red fruit, adds plushness
Graciano		5%	0–15% Acidity, colour, floral notes — the quality enhancer
Mazuelo (Carignan) *		3%	0–15% Structure and tannin

Rules: Crianza: 1 year in oak + 1 year bottle. Reserva: 1 year in oak + 2 years bottle. Gran Reserva: 2 years in oak + 3 years bottle (minimum 5 years total). Only made in exceptional vintages.

Note: The American oak vs French oak choice is the defining stylistic divide in Rioja. American oak = vanilla, coconut, dill. French oak = more restrained, cedar, subtle spice. Both are legal, both produce great wine.

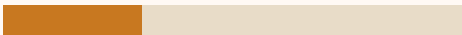
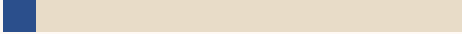
Examples: CVNE Imperial, Muga Reserva, La Rioja Alta Gran Reserva 890, Artadi, Marqués de Murrieta

Priorat

RED

Spain · DOCa Priorat — Catalonia

Ancient Garnacha and Cariñena vines grown on llicorella slate. Ultra-concentrated, mineral-driven, and intensely structured — Spain's most distinctive red wine region.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Garnacha (Grenache)		45%	20–70% Old vine concentration — mineral, dark fruit
Cariñena (Carignan)		30%	15–50% Structure, iron/graphite mineral edge
Cabernet Sauvignon *		15%	0–30% International variety — adds dark fruit and structure
Syrah *		7%	0–20% Spice and colour
Merlot *		3%	0–15% Softness and accessibility

Rules: All wines must come from the DOCa Priorat zone. Garnacha and Cariñena are the traditional varieties — both ideally old vine (30–100+ years). Old vine fruit from llicorella slate is what makes Priorat unique.

Note: Priorat was resurrected from obscurity in the late 1980s by a group of pioneering winemakers (Álvaro Palacios, René Barbier et al.) who recognised the potential of the ancient slate soils and old vines.

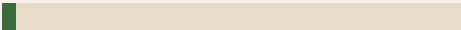
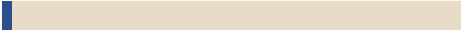
Examples: Álvaro Palacios L'Ermita, Clos Mogador, Clos de l'Obac, Vall Llach

Ribera del Duero

RED

Spain · DO Ribera del Duero — Castile and León

Tempranillo at altitude — the high plateau (850–900m) and extreme day-night temperatures produce Spain's most powerful and structured Tempranillo expressions.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Tinto Fino (Tempranillo)		90%	75–100% Must be minimum 75%. High altitude version is darker, more structured.
Cabernet Sauvignon *		5%	0–20% Adds international structure and depth
Merlot *		3%	0–15% Softens the blend
Malbec *		2%	0–10% Local historical variety — being revived

Rules: Minimum 75% Tinto Fino (Tempranillo). Garnacha Tinta and Albillo (white grape) are also permitted.

Note: Vega Sicilia, Spain's most famous wine, uses significant Cabernet Sauvignon in its blend — up to 30-40% — which is unusual and a deliberate house style going back to the 19th century.

Examples: Vega Sicilia Único, Pingus, Aalto, Protos, Pesquera

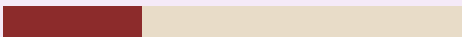
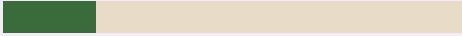
PORTUGAL

Douro Red / Vintage Port

FORTIFIED

Portugal · Douro DOC / Porto DOC

Over 80 grape varieties are permitted in the Douro — but five dominate quality Port and Douro red production. The blend creates complexity that no single variety could achieve alone.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Touriga Nacional		30%	15–60% The queen of Port — intense, floral, structured
Touriga Franca		25%	15–40% Aromatic, accessible, backbone of many blends
Tinta Roriz (Tempranillo)		20%	10–35% Colour, ripe fruit, spice
Tinta Barroca		12%	5–25% Richness and softness
Tinto Cão		8%	3–15% Acidity, complexity — rare but prized
Others (80+ varieties) *		5%	0–20% Alvarelhão, Rufete, Sousão, and many others

Rules: Port is fortified mid-fermentation by adding grape spirit (aguardente) — stopping fermentation and retaining natural grape sugar. Vintage Port is only declared in exceptional years and must be bottled within 2 years.

Note: Field blends are common in old Douro vineyards — many different varieties planted and harvested together rather than separately. This adds complexity but makes variety tracking impossible.

Examples: Quinta do Crasto, Ramos Pinto, Niepoort, Graham's, Taylor Fladgate, Quinta do Vesuvio

NEW WORLD

Meritage (US Bordeaux Blend)

RED

USA · Meritage Alliance — California · Washington · Oregon

America's answer to Bordeaux — a legally certified category requiring a blend of only Bordeaux varieties, with no single variety exceeding 90%.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Cabernet Sauvignon		65%	0–89% Usually the dominant variety in red Meritage
Merlot		20%	0–89% Softness and accessibility
Cabernet Franc		10%	0–89% Herbal lift and structure
Petit Verdot *		4%	0–20% Colour and spice
Malbec *		1%	0–15% Dark fruit and texture

Rules: Must be a blend of at least two Bordeaux varieties. No single variety may exceed 90%. Wine must be produced in the USA. White Meritage uses Sauvignon Blanc and Sémillon.

Note: The name 'Meritage' is a portmanteau of 'merit' and 'heritage' — coined to give American Bordeaux-style blends a recognisable identity. Pronounced to rhyme with 'heritage' (MER-ih-tij).

Examples: *Opus One (Napa), Dominus (Napa), Overture (Opus One second wine), Rubicon (Niebaum-Coppola)*

Australian GSM

RED

Australia · Barossa Valley · McLaren Vale · Clare Valley

Australia took the Southern Rhône GSM formula and made it its own — often more fruit-forward, sometimes more Mourvèdre-heavy than its French counterpart. Old vines are the secret.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Grenache		50%	20–70% Often from 80–150 year old vines in Barossa — enormous concentration
Shiraz		30%	15–50% More forward fruit than French Syrah
Mourvèdre (Mataro)		20%	10–40% Called 'Mataro' in Australia — earthy, gamey depth

Rules: No specific AOC rules — labeled as GSM, GSM, or by percentages at producer's discretion. Barossa and McLaren Vale are the heartland.

Note: Australia's old-vine Grenache (some of the world's oldest ungrafted vines) produces extraordinary concentration and complexity in GSM blends. The Barossa Valley's sandy soils protected vines from phylloxera.

Examples: d'Arenberg The Ironstone Pressings, Torbreck The Steading, Yangarra Estate, Coriole

Cape Blend

RED

South Africa · Western Cape — Stellenbosch · Paarl · Swartland

South Africa's signature red — Pinotage (a South African crossing of Pinot Noir and Cinsault) blended with international varieties to balance its bold character.

GRAPE		TYPICAL	RANGE
Pinotage		45%	30–70% South Africa's own grape — must be 30–70% for 'Cape Blend' designation
Cabernet Sauvignon		30%	0–40% Structure and international recognition
Merlot		15%	0–30% Softness and approachability
Shiraz *		10%	0–25% Spice and dark fruit

Rules: Cape Blend requires 30–70% Pinotage. The remaining varieties are at the winemaker's discretion. The category was officially defined to give South African wine a distinct identity.

Note: Pinotage was bred in 1925 by viticulturist Abraham Perold at Stellenbosch University — a cross between Pinot Noir and Cinsault (then known in South Africa as Hermitage, hence the name).

Examples: *Kanonkop Paul Sauer, Warwick The Blue Lady, Spice Route Pinotage, Simonsig Redhill*